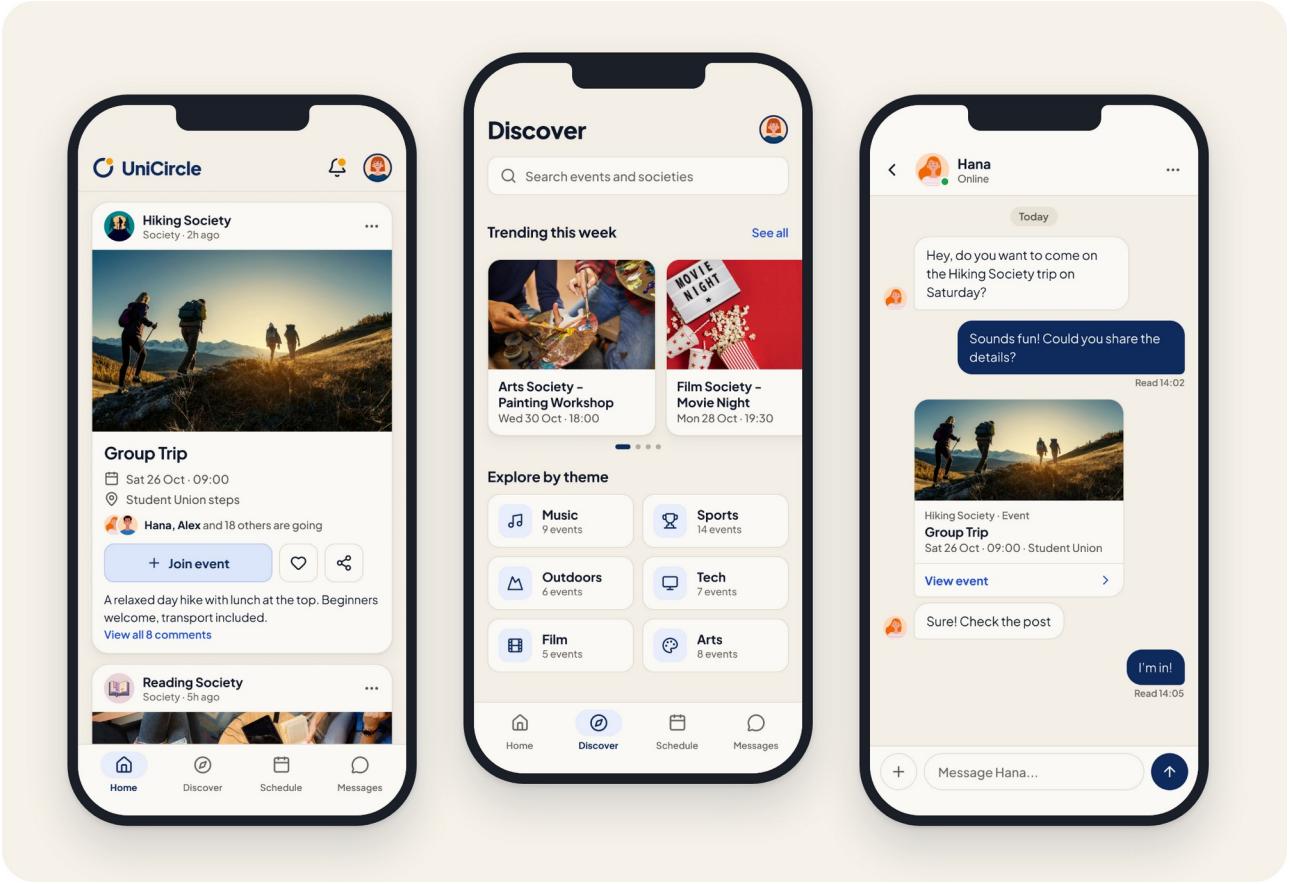
UX & PRODUCT DESIGN CASE STUDY · AYOUB ALDAWOOD

UniCircle

A mobile app that supports social connection and belonging at university by helping students find on-campus events and go with friends.

[View prototype (Figma)]



ROLE

Research, design, prototyping and testing

METHODS

Survey (10 students); think-aloud usability test (4 students)

TOOLS

Figma, Google Forms

1. Overview

UniCircle is a mobile app concept that supports social connection and belonging at university. It helps students discover on-campus events, decide which ones to join, and go with friends. I researched, designed and prototyped it, tested it with four students, and then reworked it into the final design shown here.

- **Research:** a survey of 10 students set three design goals: easy movement between finding, planning and messaging; clear feedback when joining; and personalization by interest.
- **Testing:** a think-aloud test of the first prototype (v1) produced five findings, two of them major. The same tags mark the changes they led to in the figure notes:

  Finding 1 Students were unsure whether joining an event had worked. **(Major)**

  Finding 2 Schedule cards did not look tappable, and events could not be removed. **(Major)**

  Finding 3 A TikTok-like swipe view for themed events was hard to discover and to leave.

  Finding 4 An event shared in chat did not look tappable, and read status was unclear.

  Finding 5 It was unclear which interests were selected, and what they changed.
- **Redesign:** the final design answers each finding, most visibly by replacing the swipe view with a filterable event list, and adds one visual system in which every text color meets WCAG AA contrast.
- **Next:** the final design has not been retested yet. Section 7 sets out how I would retest it.

2. The final design

The final design follows the journey of finding, joining, planning and going with friends. Numbered markers on each screen match the notes below the figure, and tags such as **Finding 1** link a change to the usability test (section 5). The interactive prototype covers the main journey: joining a hiking trip, finding it in the schedule, browsing Music events and chatting with a friend about the trip. Likes, comments, the interest chips, Remove and the Join buttons in the Music list are shown but not wired.

Joining an event

Home is where most students first meet an event, so each post carries what is needed to decide: what it is, when and where, and which friends are going. Joining takes one tap and is confirmed straight away.

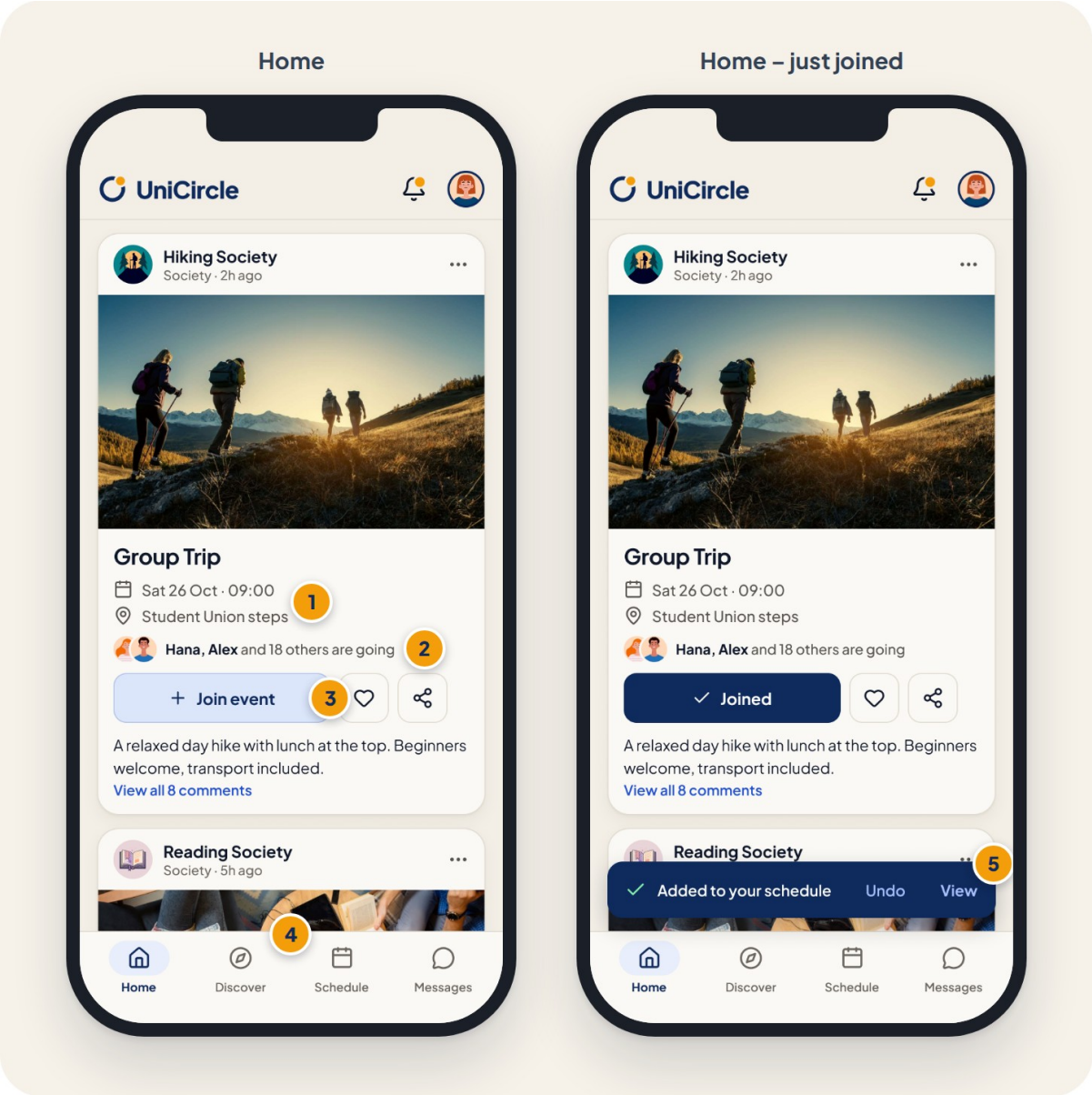


Figure 1. Home before joining (left) and just after joining (right).

1. Date, time and place sit right under the title, with icons, so the key facts can be scanned without reading the description.
2. Friends' faces and names come first. Knowing who is going is what turns browsing into joining.
3. One primary action: Join is the tinted "+" button; Like and Share are quieter outline buttons.
4. Four labeled tabs replace five icon-only ones; Profile moved to the avatar at the top right.
5. A toast confirms the join, says where the event went and offers View and Undo. Once it fades, the navy "Joined" button keeps the state visible.

Finding 1

Planning and personalizing

Schedule lists the events a student has joined, in date order, so it answers “what am I doing, and when?” without extra steps. Profile holds the interests that decide which events UniCircle puts first, so they need to be easy to read and change in one place.

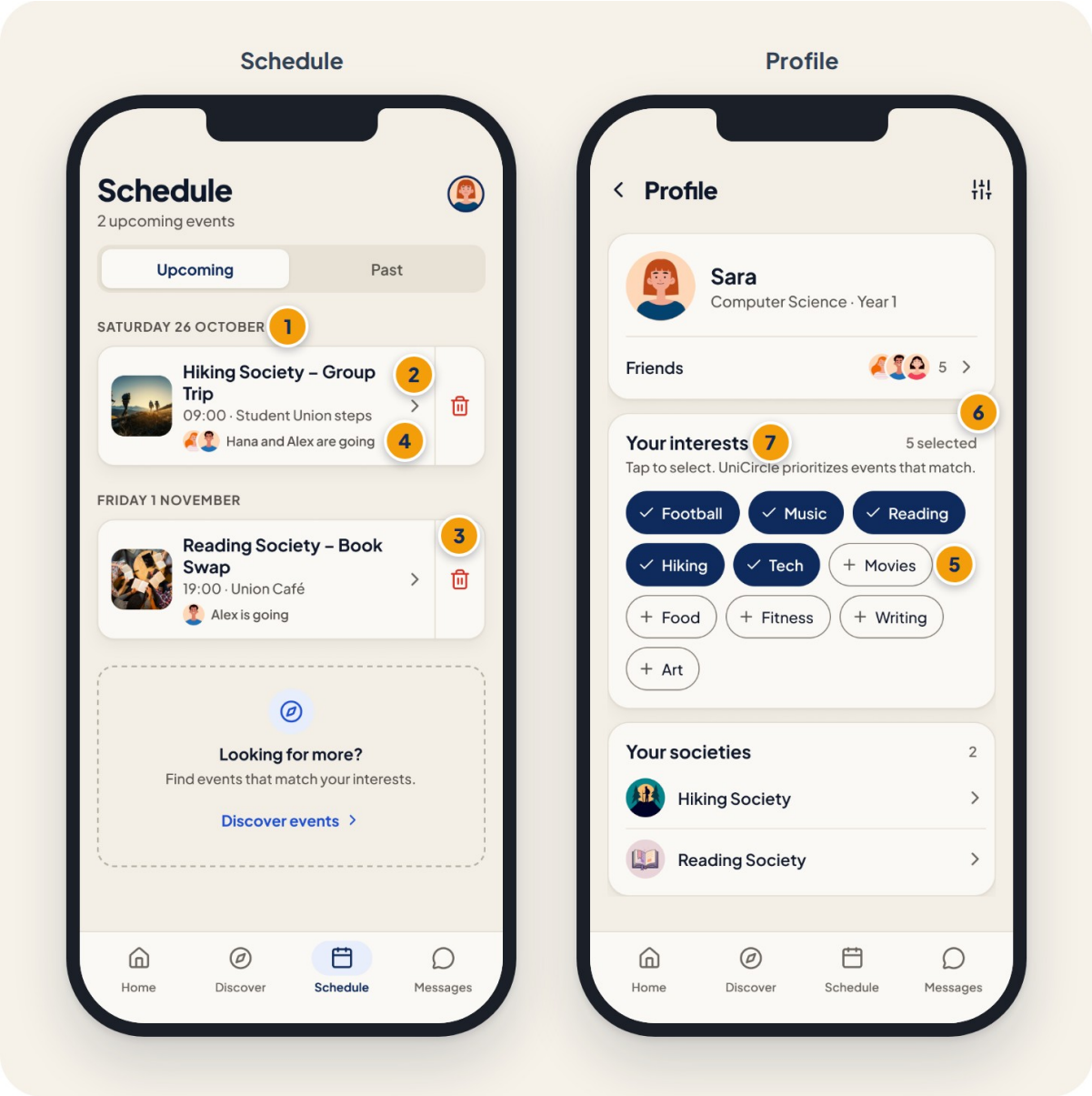


Figure 2. Schedule (left) and Profile (right).

1. Events are grouped by date, and the subtitle counts what's coming up.
2. The whole card is tappable (chevron) and opens the event. **Finding 2**
3. Remove has its own red column, away from the tap area. **Finding 2**
4. The friends shown match the post: every face has a name.
5. Selected interests are navy with a tick, unselected ones outlined with a plus, so the state doesn't rely on color alone. **Finding 5**
6. “5 selected” and the helper text explain the effect: matching events get prioritized. **Finding 5**
7. Viewing and editing happen on one screen, with no separate edit mode. **Finding 5**

Discovering events

Discover is for browsing beyond the feed: trending events, and themes that open a focused list.

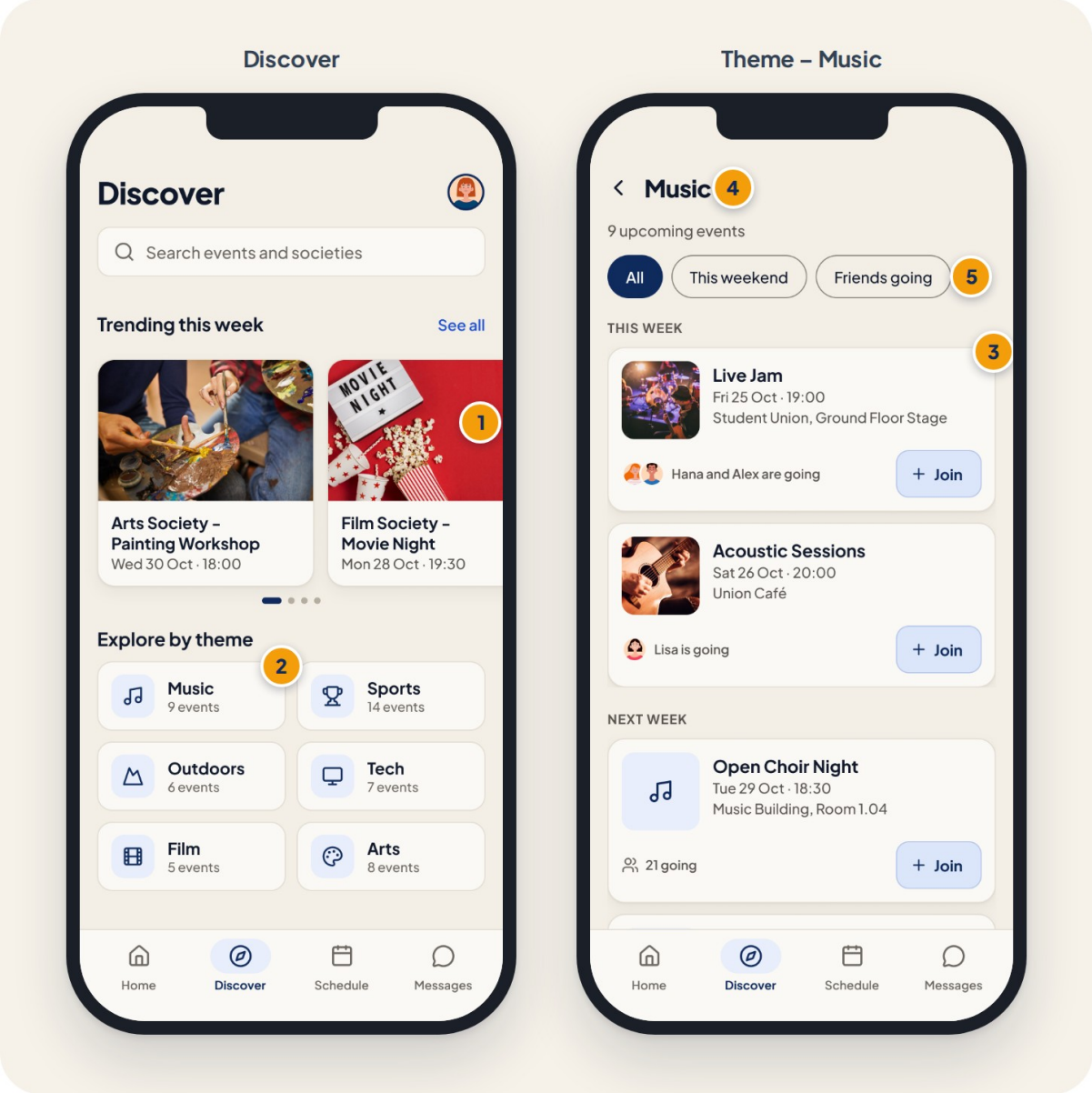


Figure 3. Discover (left) and the Music event list (right).

1. Trending cards scroll sideways; the next card peeks in, so it's clear there's more.
2. Themes are ordered by the interests Sara picked on her Profile, so Music comes first.
3. A list instead of a TikTok-like full-screen swipe view: day, time, place and friends compare at a glance. **Finding 3**
4. Back arrow and tab bar stay, so leaving works like everywhere else in the app. **Finding 3**
5. Filters and week groups narrow the list; Join works straight from it.

Coordinating with friends

Going with friends is the point of the app, so Messages makes it easy to see who has replied and to share an event in a form that opens in one tap.

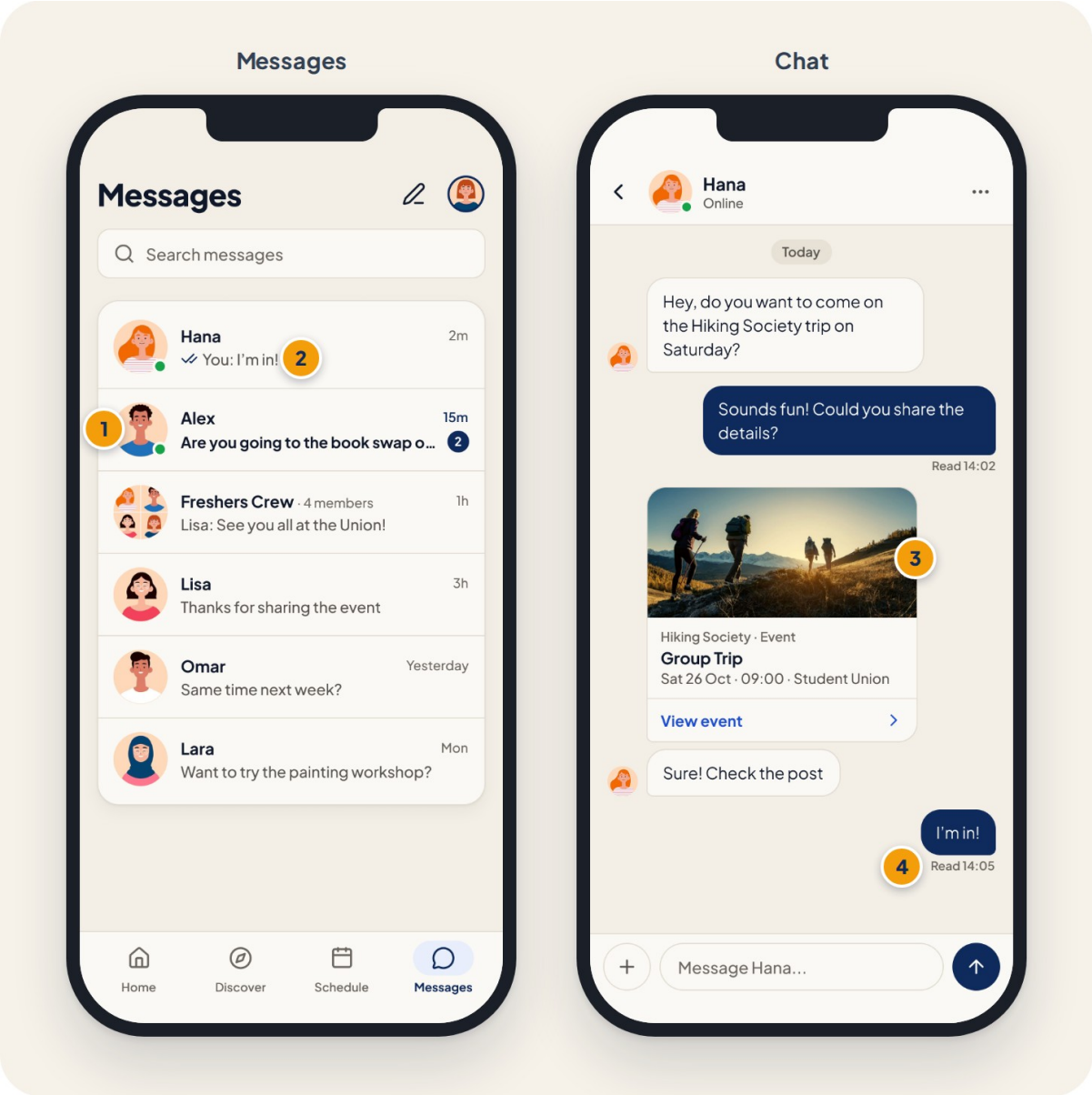


Figure 4. Messages (left) and a chat with Hana, who has shared the hiking trip (right).

1. Unread conversations stand out: bold preview, navy time, count badge.
2. Green dot for online; the list already shows "You: I'm in!" as read.
3. The shared event is a full card: photo, details and "View event ›", tappable as a whole. **Finding 4**
4. "Read" and the time appear under sent messages. **Finding 4**

3. Design system

All screens are built in Figma from 20 color variables, 20 text styles and a set of components, so each color, type size and state is defined once and reused. Figure 5 shows the core of each. Of the color variables, it shows the seven color roles; the other 13 are supporting shades for text, borders, surfaces and use on navy. Of the text styles, it shows six of the ten type sizes; the other four are for the wordmark, card titles, small supporting text and tab labels, and the 20 styles are these ten sizes in different weights. Components have variants for their states, such as the Join button (before and after joining; large and compact) and the tab bar, and larger components reuse smaller ones: the event list card contains the Join button. Spacing and shape follow fixed rules too: tap targets are at least 44 × 44, and corner radii come from a set scale.



Figure 5. The seven color roles, type scale, key components, and spacing & shape.

How I got there

The research, testing and decisions behind the final design.

4. Problem and research

Starting university means building a social life almost from scratch. Societies run many events, but news of them is spread across posters, group chats and social media, and going alone can be daunting. Students, especially in their first year, need one place to see what is on, decide quickly, and know who else is going.

To check which features would matter most, I ran a short online survey with 10 students. The most chosen options were group chat or community features (9 of 10), event discovery (8 of 10) and matching students by shared interests (7 of 10).

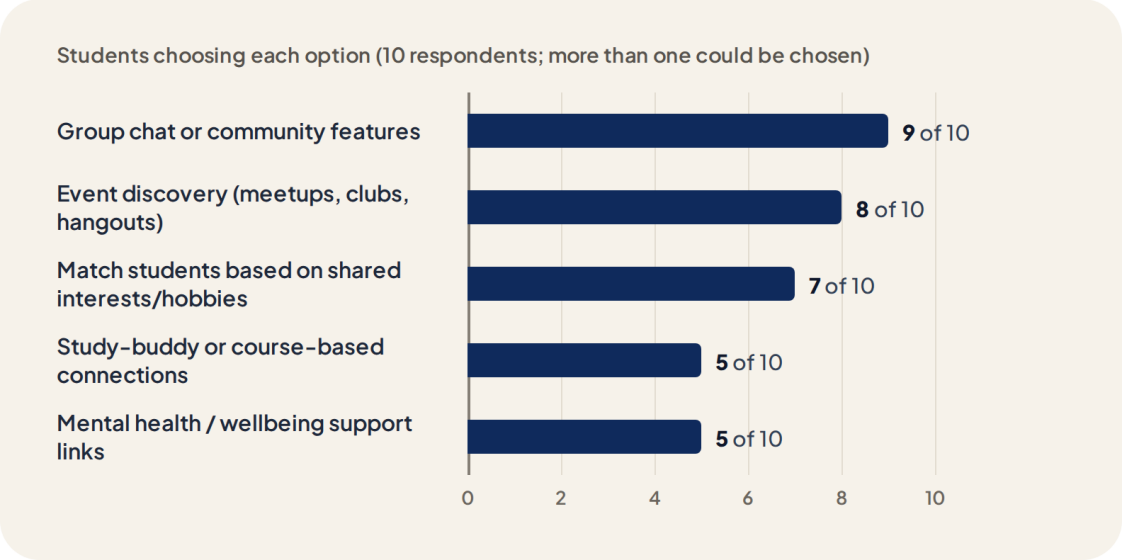


Figure 6. Survey responses: "What features would you find most useful in a student social-connection tool?" (10 students; more than one option could be chosen).

Five further ideas were written in under "Other", one mention each: a chat-based app, a swipe-up feature similar to TikTok, an interactive interface similar to Instagram, a trip buddy, and discovering hobbies. From these results I set three design goals:

1. **Simple movement** between finding events, planning attendance and messaging friends.
2. **Clear results:** joining or leaving an event should visibly change what the student sees.
3. **Personalization:** students can tailor what they see to their interests.

5. First prototype and usability test

I first sketched the main screens as low-fidelity wireframes (Figure 7), then built them in Figma as a high-fidelity, clickable prototype (v1), which is the version I tested. The prototype put five sections in an icon-only bottom bar: Home, Discover, Schedule, Messages and Profile. Home showed society posts with a Join button. Discover offered themes, and the Music theme opened a full-screen view where students swiped up through events one at a time, as on TikTok. Messages included a chat in which a friend had shared an event, and interests were viewed and edited on separate screens.

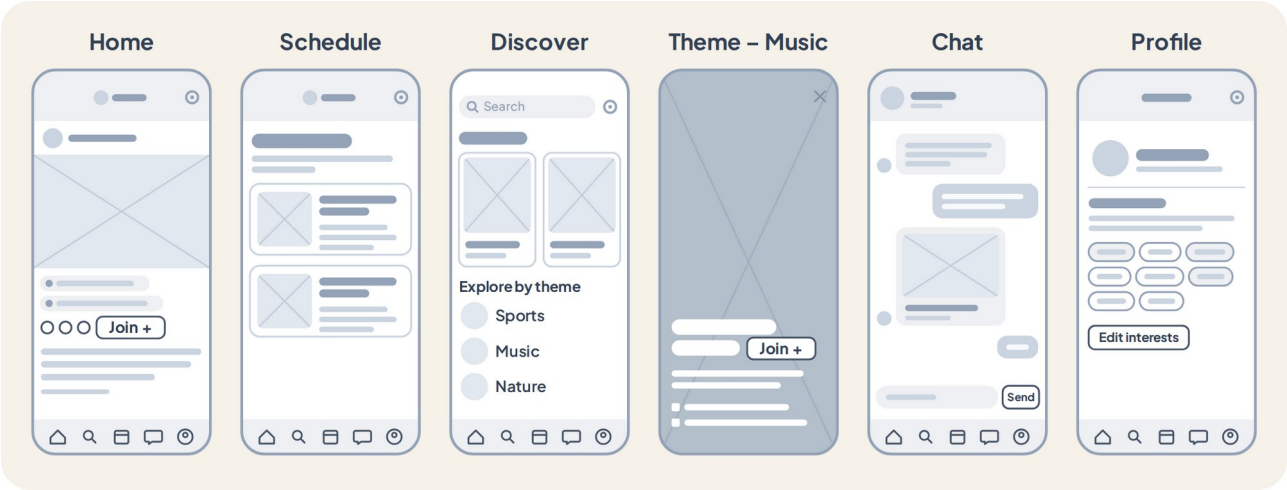


Figure 7. Wireframes for v1, the high-fidelity prototype used in testing.

Method

- **Prototype:** v1, a high-fidelity, clickable Figma prototype.
- **Participants:** four first-year students from different degree programs. All were regular smartphone users who had not seen UniCircle before.
- **Sessions:** think-aloud, task-based, about 20 minutes each, in a quiet study room on campus.
- **Tasks:** join an event; find the joined event and open it again; explore the Music theme; open a friend's chat and the event shared there; review and change interests.
- **Data:** observer notes on actions, errors and comments; approximate completion times; and a severity rating for each finding, from 1 (cosmetic) to 4 (critical).

Findings

All four participants liked the concept, but the test produced five findings (Table 1).

Finding	What happened in v1	Severity
Finding 1	After tapping Join, participants were unsure whether it had worked or where the event had gone. Nothing obvious changed, so they did not think to check Schedule.	**3 · Major**
Finding 2	Cards in Schedule did not look tappable, and there was no way to remove an event once joined.	**3 · Major**
Finding 3	In the full-screen Music view, some did not notice they could swipe for more events, or the small X that closed it. They tried the phone's back gesture instead.	2 · Minor
Finding 4	In Chat, the shared event card did not look tappable, and participants could not tell whether their messages had been read.	2 · Minor
Finding 5	Interests were viewed and edited on separate screens. Some participants were unsure which chips were selected or what selecting them would do.	2 · Minor

Table 1. Findings from the usability test of v1, with severity ratings (1 cosmetic, 2 minor, 3 major, 4 critical).

6. From findings to redesign

Each finding led to a specific change (Table 2). Together they also showed a pattern: v1 often acted without telling people what had happened, or relied on gestures they could not discover. So the redesign went beyond individual fixes to a consistent structure and visual system.

Finding	Change in the final design
Finding 1 **Join feedback**	A toast confirms the join, says the event was added to the schedule, and offers View and Undo. The button then stays navy, reading "Joined". This keeps the system status visible (Nielsen, 1994) and makes the action easy to reverse (Shneiderman et al., 2016).
Finding 2 **Schedule**	Each card is tappable as a whole, with a chevron, and opens the event. Remove sits in its own red column, apart from the tap area.
Finding 3 **Music theme**	The swipe view was replaced by a list with filters, a back arrow and the tab bar (see below).
Finding 4 **Chat**	The shared event is a full card with photo, details and "View event ›", tappable as a whole. Sent messages show "Read" and the time.
Finding 5 **Interests**	Viewing and editing happen on one Profile screen. Selected chips are navy with a tick, unselected ones outlined with a plus, and a count with helper text explains the effect.

Table 2. How each finding was addressed in the final design.

Navigation

Five icon-only tabs became four labeled ones: Home, Discover, Schedule and Messages. Labels remove the guesswork that icons alone leave. Profile moved to the avatar at the top right, and Settings moved into Profile. The result has two levels (Figure 8): tab screens that switch instantly, and deeper screens that slide in and close with a back arrow, which gives students a predictable model of where they are (Norman, 2013).

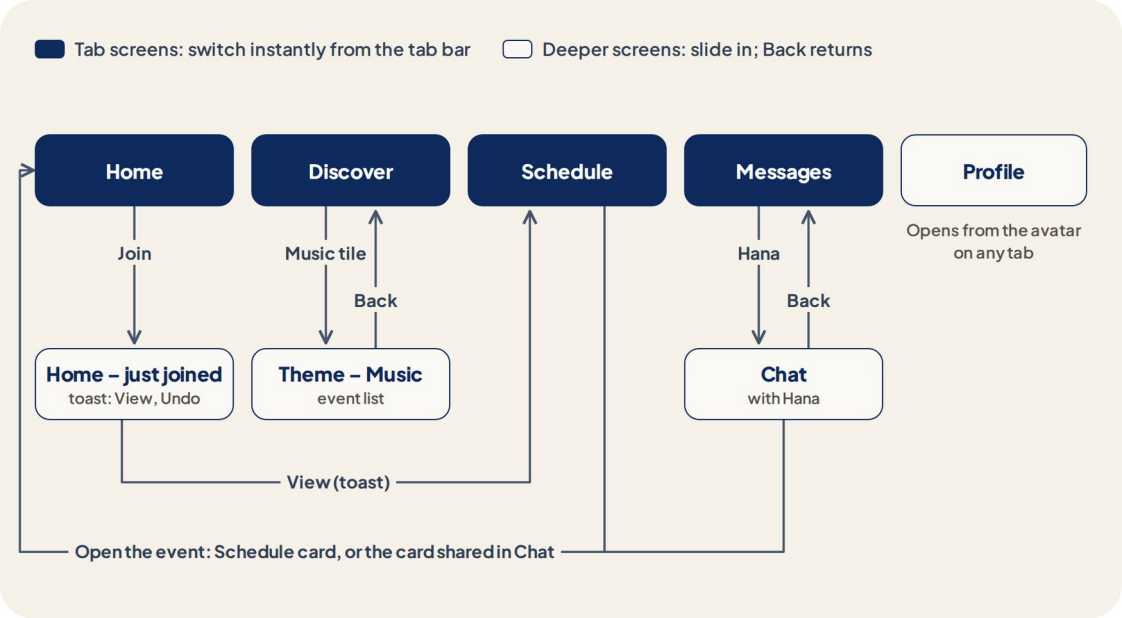


Figure 8. Navigation structure. Tab screens switch instantly; deeper screens slide in and return with Back. Profile opens from the avatar on any tab.

Replacing the swipe view

For finding 3, I compared three options (Figure 9): (A) keep the full-screen swipe view and add stronger hints; (B) replace it with a list; (C) show a list that opens the swipe view. I chose B. Choosing an event means comparing day, time, place and who is going, which a list shows at a glance. Swiping would also be the only gesture of its kind in the app, and the list keeps joining to one tap. Filters (All, This weekend, Friends going) narrow the list, and events are grouped by week.

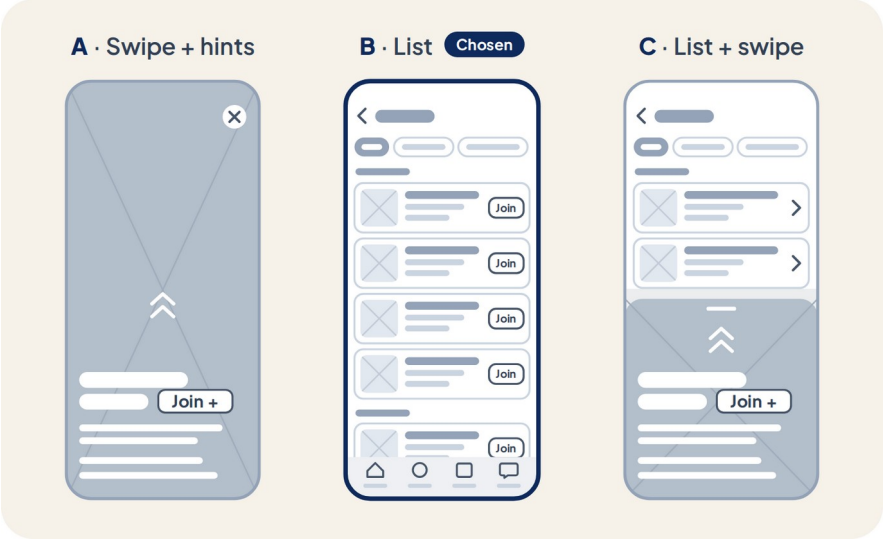


Figure 9. Options for the Music theme: (A) swipe view with hints, (B) list, (C) list that opens the swipe view. B was chosen.

Color and type

The earlier palette used one dusty-rose hue for almost everything, so actions, states and decoration looked alike, and some text failed WCAG AA contrast (W3C, 2018): the logo on the header measured 2.3:1 and the Send button 2.5:1. Now each color has one job: blue means tappable, navy means brand or selected, amber is for rare highlights, green confirms success or shows who is online, and red is only for removal. Every text pair meets the 4.5:1 minimum, and one typeface, Plus Jakarta Sans, with a fixed type scale replaced four mixed ones (Figure 5).

Content rules

Two small rules keep the screens consistent. Titles name the society only where it is not already shown: “Group Trip” under the Hiking Society header, but “Hiking Society – Group Trip” in the schedule. And every face has a name: the avatars beside “Hana and Alex are going” are Hana and Alex.

7. Next steps

Retest

I would retest the final design with five students who have not used UniCircle before, using the same think-aloud method and five tasks so the results compare directly with v1. Five users are enough to uncover most usability problems (Nielsen, 2000). Each check passes if at least four of the five meet it. The retest would verify that:

1. **System status:** users immediately recognize that joining worked from the toast and the button alone. Finding 1
2. **Signifiers:** users treat Schedule cards as tappable and find Remove without help. Finding 2
3. **User control:** users browse, filter and leave the Music list without help. Finding 3
4. **Feedback:** users open the shared event from Chat on their first try and can tell whether their message was read. Finding 4
5. **Mental model:** users can tell which interests are selected and explain how they change the events shown. Finding 5

Design

- **Event details screen:** a dedicated screen with an event's full details, opened from Schedule and Chat. For now, the prototype opens the event's Home post instead.
- **Removing an event from Schedule:** a toast confirms the removal, with an Undo option, the same way joining is confirmed.
- **First-time use:** a short onboarding that asks new students for their interests, so relevant events appear from their first visit.

8. Reflection

- **A request is not evidence.** One survey respondent asked for a TikTok-style swipe feature; in testing, people could not tell they could swipe, or how to leave. Ideas from users are a starting point that still needs testing.
- **Some fixes are structural.** Adding hints to the swipe view would have treated the symptom. The findings pointed to the structure itself, so the view became a list.
- **Every action should answer back.** Most findings were moments when the app stayed silent. The final design makes each action respond: a toast, a changed button, a read receipt.
- **Small rules add up.** Rules like “every face has a name” go unnoticed when followed, but breaking them is what makes an interface feel unreliable.

References

Nielsen, J. (1994) ‘10 usability heuristics for user interface design’, Nielsen Norman Group.

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